

Proficiency in English – I

The status of English in India, the sound and rhythm of spoken English, critical reading of real texts, and the working vocabulary a primary teacher must have at their fingertips.

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CREDITS	MARKS	PERIODS / WEEK	UNIT WEIGHTS
2	35 Ext + 15 Int = 50	2–3	5 / 10 / 10 / 10

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Status of English

● 1.1 Historical Perspective of English in India

English reached India with ships, not with missionaries. The East India Company set up its first factory at Surat in 1613 and traded out of Madras, Bombay and Calcutta through the seventeenth century. It needed people who could read contracts, correspond with London, keep accounts and negotiate with Indian rulers and merchants — it did not think of education at all, it thought of clerks. English teaching grew out of that commercial and administrative need, and for a century it was job-oriented instruction for a small administrative elite, not a national education system.

Two documents mark the formalisation of English-medium education: Lord **Macaulay's Minute of 1835**, which visualised English as the language of teaching and of the higher courts, and **Lord Wood's Despatch of 1854**, sometimes called the *Magna Carta of English education in India*.

TABLE 1.1 — THE LANDMARK DOCUMENTS AND POLICY INSTRUMENTS GOVERNING ENGLISH IN INDIA

Document	Year	What it says about English
Committee of Public Instruction, report	1832	English for the higher branches of learning; vernaculars pushed aside where English teaching was unavailable. Marked the formal beginning of the English-vs-vernacular debate
Macaulay's Minute	1835	English as the medium of administration, courts and higher learning; one uniform type of education. Gave the political justification for an English-educated administrative class
Wood's Despatch	1854	English the medium of instruction for higher education; education departments in the provinces, an inspectorate, and government colleges. The institutional structure of English education in India — its "Magna Carta"
Constitution, Part XVII	1950	Hindi (Devanagari) is the language of the Union; English may be used for official purposes alongside it, and is named the <i>Associate Official language</i>

Document	Year	What it says about English
Eighth Schedule	1950, amended	Recognises 22 languages; English is not one of them
Official Languages Act	1963	Gives English continuing official status; provides for a Commission of Official Languages
National Policy on Education	1968	Institutes the three-language formula in schools; English as a subject and a link language rather than a universal medium
National Curriculum Framework	2005	Mother tongue / regional language as the medium; English as subject and link language
National Education Policy	2020	English (or an Indian language) may be the medium from the foundational stage; MT / regional as the medium till at least Grade 5

Wood's Despatch of 1854 did three things at once: it made English the medium of instruction at the higher stage, it required each province to have a Department of Public Instruction, and it established an inspectorate. Almost every English-medium institution in India descends from that administrative design.

After Independence the arrangement was never dismantled. English continued as the medium of higher education and the working language of the courts, the civil services, science and technology, and as the bridge between Indian languages. **NPE 1968** gave the three-language formula its canonical form and **NPE 1985** reiterated it. **NCF 2005** shifted the balance: the medium in government schools should be the mother tongue or the local/regional language, English-medium schools were to be converted gradually, and English would remain a subject and a link language. **NEP 2020** took this further, allowing English (or an Indian language) as the medium from the *foundational stage* wherever possible and keeping the mother tongue or local/regional language as the medium at least till Grade 5.

● 1.2 English Around Us; English as a Global Language

Take a day in the life of an ordinary family in Guwahati. English appears without announcing itself. The child reads the instructions on a medicine bottle, recognises a brand name on a television channel, listens to a safety announcement at a railway station, checks a weather forecast, types a password, sends a message to a cousin in Dubai. Almost none of this is "English lesson" material, but all of it is English. This is what "English around us" means: English has become a *utility* of daily life through print, signage and screens, and the child acquires it incidentally long before anyone teaches it formally.

Globally, English is the most widely learned second language in history — the working language of international organisations, science publishing, aviation, the internet and entertainment. It is the only language with a genuinely global presence, because it grew as the language of a colonial power in several continents and was then adopted by speakers who had no colonial stake in it. For an Indian teacher this matters: English is not simply the "language of the former ruler", but also the language African, South-East Asian and South American speakers chose for their own reasons.

TABLE 1.2 — DOMAINS IN WHICH ENGLISH IS ENCOUNTERED, AND WHAT THE ENCOUNTER TEACHES

Domain	Example the child meets	What is acquired incidentally
Signage and public information	Road signs, railway announcements, bank counters, hospital boards	Fixed chunks and formulaic language ("Would you like to proceed?", "Kindly wait")
Print	Newspaper headlines, medicine labels, food packets, exam question papers	Letter-sound awareness, word order, register differences
Broadcast and digital media	English news channels, dubbed programmes with English subtitles, social media, search engines, chat, games	Listening fluency, connected speech, stress and intonation; informal register, texting abbreviations, global peer norms
Work, aspiration and family	Job notices requiring "good English", coaching advertisements, community notices, wedding invitations	The economic motivation that keeps English a high-demand subject; polite forms and respect registers

● 1.3 Place of English in the School Curriculum: NCF and NEP

For most of the twentieth century a child in India who wanted to reach university had to study through the medium of English. **NCF 2005** and **NEP 2020** articulate the new consensus. The direction is not anti-English; it is *against English displacing the language of the child's life* at the stage where the child is still learning to read and to think.

NEP 2020 extends the NCF logic with a *foundational stage* covering ages 3 to 8, in which an English-medium or an Indian-language-medium environment may be provided wherever possible, with the mother tongue or local/regional language as the medium at least until Grade 5 and preferably till Grade 8. The *National Curriculum for Foundational Stage for School Education (NCF-FS)*, 2022 operationalises this with goals in three language areas: **W** (native / local language / mother tongue), **L1** (a familiar language such as a tribal language) and **L2** (a further language, often but not necessarily English). English appears early as a subject alongside the medium of instruction, not as a replacement for it.

TABLE 1.3 — ENGLISH IN THE CURRICULUM: THE EARLIER POSITION AND THE PRESENT POSITION

Question	Earlier dominant position	NCF 2005 / NEP 2020 position
Medium at the elementary stage	English, especially in private and aided schools	Mother tongue / local / regional language; English-medium schools to be converted gradually
Status of English	The gate to higher education and employment	A subject, a link language and a bridge language; still valued, but not the sole gateway
When does English begin?	Class I, often before the child has schooled a first language	At the foundational stage, as L2 / bridge, with the mother tongue as the medium
Up to which stage in the vernacular?	Often none — English throughout	At least till Grade 5, preferably till Grade 8
Teacher's role	Transmission of English forms	Multilingual classroom; English taught through the medium the child understands

A Class III group in which some children speak Assamese, some a tribal language, and two only English at home. A workable arrangement under NEP 2020: teach

concepts, stories and instructions in the majority home language while narrating key English words and phrases; display every new English word with a picture; let children answer in whichever language they have, and require English only for the target words. Rejecting a correct answer in Assamese teaches a child that the language in which he thinks is worthless.

● 1.4 Constitutional Provision; Associate Official Language; the Three-Language Formula

Under **Part XVII** of the Constitution of India, dealing with Languages, the **language of the Union is Hindi** in Devanagari script; the official purposes of the Union may, however, be carried on in English as well. The Constitution does not name English an "official language" in the same way Hindi is named — it names it the *Associate Official language*. The **Eighth Schedule** lists 22 languages recognised by the Constitution and gives them special status, though English is not one of them; the **Official Languages Act, 1963** provides the working rules and created the **Commission of Official Languages**.

COMMON MISTAKE

English is **not** the national language of India. India has no national language. Hindi is the official language of the Union; English is an *Associate Official language* for official purposes.

The **three-language formula** belongs to the education system rather than to the Constitution, but it has been policy since 1968. In its earliest NCERT version every child was to learn the mother tongue (or regional language), a language from the "other" regional group, and English. In the NEP 2020 formulation the three languages are: the *mother tongue or home/local language*; the *local/regional language or another Indian language*; and a *foreign or additional language* — with English occupying the third slot, or being introduced early as a bridge, depending on the state.

● 1.5 L1, L2 and Foreign Language in the Context of English

L1, L2 and foreign language are useful as *descriptions of a particular child's linguistic situation at a particular moment*, not as three permanently separate boxes. The **first language (L1)** is the language a child understands and speaks best, normally acquired at home before school; it is the language in which the child thinks and counts. The **second language (L2)** is learnt after the first and used for wider purposes — school, marketplace, media. The **foreign language** is not used in the immediate community and has no colonial or administrative history in the country.

Now place English in that scheme. In an **English-medium school in Assam**, a child who arrives speaking Assamese is learning English as an L2 — second in order of acquisition, and the one the school uses. In an **Assamese-medium school**, a child meets English as a foreign language in the everyday sense, though because English comes with books, examinations and administrative work it behaves more like an L2. French or German in either school is a foreign language in the strict sense: no home use, no community use, no administrative use.

TABLE 1.5 — L1, L2 AND FOREIGN LANGUAGE COMPARED, IN AN ASSAMESE CLASSROOM

Basis	First language (L1)	Second language (L2)	Foreign language
Typical example	Assamese; a tribal or regional language (Mising, Bodo, Karbi)	English in an English-medium school; a neighbouring Indian language	French, German, Japanese
Where acquired	Home, family, neighbourhood, before school	Classroom, books, media, peers	Classroom, textbook, occasional media
Domain of use	Home, worship, market, conversation with relatives, inner speech	School, shop, office, letters, news, further study	Very little outside the textbook
Learner's attitude	Automatic, unselfconscious	Effortful, but useful and worth acquiring	Effortful, remote, easily deferred
Teacher's stance	Respect and use; never punished	Bridge; taught with support in L1	Introduced gradually, with cultural context

The home language is an *asset*, not a deficiency. **Additive multilingualism** means a new language is added to what the child already has, so that she ends up with more languages, not fewer; **subtractive bilingualism** means a new language replaces the first, which for a child still acquiring concepts is a loss. NEP 2020 and NCF 2005 both stand on the additive side.

● Activities for Unit 1

- 1. Listing out familiar English words used in day-to-day life.** Make a list of English words met outside school in one day — from shop signboards, medicine labels, television, mobile screens, bus tickets, road signs, bank slips, messages. A useful extension is to classify them: loanwords that have entered Assamese usage, purely English words, and brand names.
- 2. Classroom discussion on the use of English in day-to-day life and in classroom situations.** Run it with four questions: Where do I meet English outside school? In what situations is English *necessary*, and in what situations is another language better? When did I last speak English? What stops children from speaking English in the playground?

UNIT 1 QUICK REVIEW — STATUS OF ENGLISH

KEY TERMS

Associate Official language · Eighth Schedule · Official Languages Act, 1963 · three-language formula · link language · bridge language · additive multilingualism

REMEMBER

- ▶ Macaulay's Minute – 1835; Committee of Public Instruction's report – 1832; Wood's Despatch – 1854, which created the departments of education, the inspectorate and the government colleges.
- ▶ English is an **Associate Official language**, not the national language. The Eighth Schedule lists 22 languages and English is not among them.
- ▶ NCF 2005: mother tongue / regional language as the medium; English as a subject and a link language. NEP 2020: MT / regional as the medium at least till Grade 5, preferably till Grade 8; NCF-FS 2022 gives the goals W, L1 and L2.
- ▶ In an English-medium school in Assam, English functions as the child's **L2**.

QUESTIONS

VSA What is the constitutional status of English in India? Why is it wrong to call it the national language?

SA Explain the three-language formula and show how it has been adapted under NEP 2020.

LA "The history of English education in India is the history of administrative convenience." Critically examine this with reference to 1835, 1854 and the post-Independence period. (10)

UNIT 2 • 10 MARKS

Understanding Language: Listening to and Producing Oral Discourses

● 2.1 Language as Communication and Thinking; the Language-Rich Classroom

Language does two jobs at once. As a **means of communication**, it lets one person share an idea or a feeling with another. As a **means of thinking**, it lets a person work inside an idea at all: a child who has no word for "compare" cannot easily hold two objects side by side and judge between them. Education is limited by the conceptual apparatus of the language in which it is done, which is why the medium of instruction is a policy question and not only an administrative one.

Language richness is not the amount of English spoken by the teacher. It is the *density of meaningful language that children hear, use and have to think in*, across the day and across the subjects.

TABLE 2.1 — FEATURES OF A LANGUAGE-RICH CLASSROOM AND HOW TO ORGANISE THEM

Feature	What it looks like	How a teacher organises it
Print in the environment	Words, sentences, charts and stories on walls, corners and desks	An "English word wall" of 20 high-frequency words with pictures; labelled classroom objects; a display of children's own writing
Talk in every subject	Children talk about history, science and maths, not only in English periods	Require an explanation in words before a child may hold up an object; use think-pair-share before every written answer
Dialogue, not recitation	Children ask and answer questions of each other	Assign roles; run a "question box"; teach four question stems as sentence frames
Response to real purposes	Language used to get something done	Class newspaper, a school announcement, a request letter to the head teacher, a survey of the vegetable market
Explicit vocabulary work	New words met before they are needed	Pre-teach five words with pictures and gesture before a story; use the word three times within the same day
Multiple languages honoured	Home languages used for thinking and drafting	Let children explain first in L1 and then in English; label displays in two languages

TABLE 2.2 — RECEPTIVE AND PRODUCTIVE SKILLS: WHAT EACH DEMANDS OF THE LEARNER

Aspect	Receptive skills (listening, reading)	Productive skills (speaking, writing)
Direction of language	Incoming — the learner receives	Outgoing — the learner produces
Time available	Fixed and unpausable; the text moves on	The producer controls pace and revision
Main difficulty	Holding information in short-term memory	Retrieving the right word under pressure
Main resource	Context and prediction	Repertoire of chunks and sentence frames
Best classroom model	Read-aloud, storytelling, announcements, songs, peer talk	Role play, dialogue, retelling, discussion, debate, presentation
Typical error	Missing the point because one unknown word blocks the clause	Freezing — the child says nothing rather than risk a mistake

● 2.2.1 Listening with Comprehension

Listening is the most neglected skill in the primary classroom, and the most important. It is also the hardest, because a listener has no time to look a word up: by the time the meaning of a sentence clicks, three more clauses have passed. What makes listening possible is *prediction* — the listener uses context, situation, topic and grammatical expectation to anticipate what is coming, and so is never really lost.

For a primary teacher, listening with comprehension means building graded tasks.

Global listening asks what the whole talk is about — "Is the speaker complaining or apologising?" **Selective listening** asks for specific items — "How many people are mentioned? What time is the train?" **Detailed listening** requires the fine grain — "Why was the bag left on the chair?" A child who can only do global listening is not ready for a story, but is ready for an announcement.

Three habits make a teacher a better listener-model, and children copy the habits.

Signal the structure first: "Listen. I am going to tell you three things." **Signal the boundaries:** pause at the end of each part. **Signal the key word:** stress it and write it on the board as you speak. Above all, teach the class the phrase "Could you say that again, please?" as a legitimate, confident move rather than a failure.

● 2.2.2 Segmental Features: the Sound System of English (IPA)

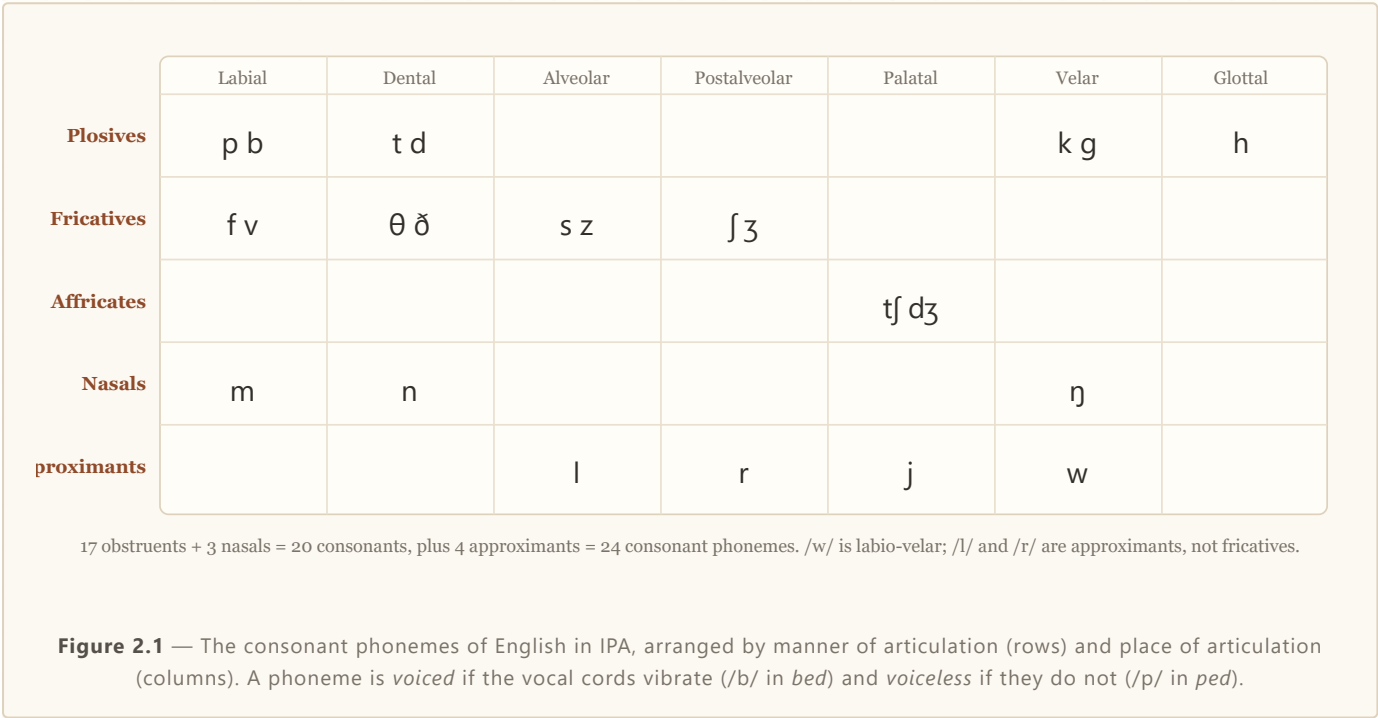
Every stretch of spoken English is built out of a small, fixed inventory of sounds. A **segment** is the smallest unit of a language that can make a difference of meaning; in phonetics the segments of speech are the **phonemes**. English has **44 phonemes**: **24 consonants** (17 obstruents + 3 nasals + 4 approximants) and **20 vowels** (12 monophthongs and 8 diphthongs).

The phoneme is defined not by its sound alone but by the *contrast* it makes: two phones count as different phonemes only if substituting one for the other can change the meaning of a word. That is why English sound is analysed **phonemically**, and why it is taught with the **International Phonetic Alphabet**

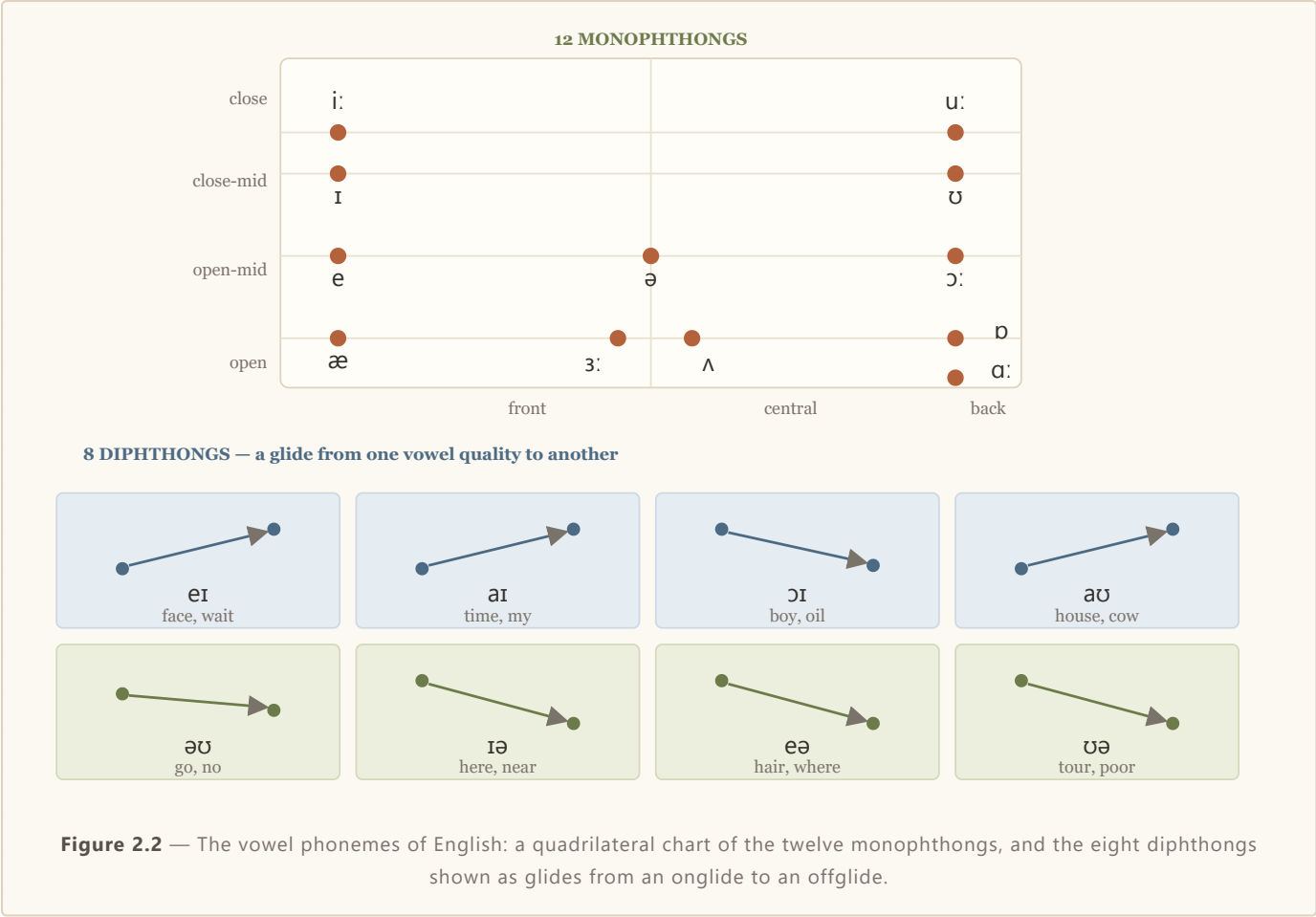
(IPA) — a single agreed set of symbols that removes the ambiguities of ordinary spelling.

DEFINITION

Phoneme: the smallest unit of sound that can change the meaning of a word. **Phone:** the actual sound produced, which varies with accent and context. **Minimal pair:** two words differing in exactly one phoneme but in meaning (*ship* /ʃɪp/ – *sheep* /ʃi:p/). **Allophone:** a predictable variant of a phoneme, not a separate one (the clear l of *light* and the dark l of *milk* are both /l/). **Segmental features** are carried by individual phonemes — *manner* (plosive, fricative, affricate, nasal, approximant) and *place* (labial, dental, alveolar, postalveolar, palatal, velar, glottal), with voicing, aspiration and length. **Suprasegmental features** (2.2.3) operate over stretches longer than one phoneme.



English vowels are taught as twelve pure vowels (**monophthongs**) and eight gliding vowels (**diphthongs**). The monophthongs are plotted in a quadrilateral by *height* (close to open) and *backness* (front to back). The symbols /æ/ ("ash") and /ɑ/ (open o) are peculiar to English.



English uses the same sound resources to build differences in *voicing* (/p/–/b/), *place* (/m/–/n/), *manner* (/s/–/ʃ/), *length* (/ɪ/–/i:/) and *lip-rounding* (/ʊ/–/ɔ:/) at the core of its sound system. Each pair below differs in exactly one phoneme; if the two words of a pair are not distinguished, the listener hears a word, not a meaning.

TABLE 2.3 — CONTRASTIVE MINIMAL PAIRS, GROUPED BY THE TYPE OF CONTRAST			
Contrast	Minimal pair (IPA)	Contrast	Minimal pair (IPA)
Voicing, plosive	pen /pen/ – Ben /ben/	Voicing, plosive	ten /ten/ – den /den/
Voicing, plosive	cot /kɒt/ – got /gɒt/	Voicing, fricative	fan /fæn/ – van /væn/
Voicing, fricative	think /θɪŋk/ – this /ðɪs/	Voicing, fricative	sip /sɪp/ – zip /zɪp/
Place, fricative	measure /'æɡə/ – mansion /'ænʃən/	Length, vowel	ship /ʃɪp/ – sheep /ʃi:p/
Frontness, vowel	bed /bed/ – bad /bæd/	Backness, vowel	cup /kʌp/ – carp /kɑ:p/

Two points about the symbols are worth remembering. /ʒ/ is **marginal in English**: it appears in a handful of loanwords — *measure, vision, garage, usual, genre, television* — and in a few compounds such as *show* and *routeau*, but it is not a productive phoneme of native English. And /tʃ/ and /dʒ/ are single affricate phonemes, while /tr/ and /dr/ are consonant clusters, not single phonemes.

KEY IDEA — AN ASSAMESE ASSET

Assamese already distinguishes an **aspirated series** /p:/, /t:/, /k:/ alongside unaspirated and voiced stops — a three-way contrast English does not have. Point to the Assamese contrast and say simply that English uses

only the unaspirated member. Assamese also has **retroflex consonants** (/ʈ/, /ʋ/, /ɳ/) that English lacks, so warn against substituting retroflexion for English /t/, /d/, /n/, /ʃ/. The standard difficulties run the other way: Assamese has no /v/, /z/, /ʒ/ or /ʒ/, so *very*, *zoo*, *ship* and *measure* are the classic substitution targets.

● 2.2.3 Suprasegmental Features: Stress, Rhythm, Intonation

Two utterances can be built from exactly the same phonemes and still mean different things. "*I said the **sheep** is fine*" uses the same phonemes as "*I said the **ship** is fine*"; the difference is a fall of pitch on one stressed syllable. Features that work this way — over stretches of speech rather than over single sounds — are called **suprasegmental features**, and they carry as much meaning as the consonants and vowels do. In fact they usually carry more: a child's errors here make the listener stumble far more often than errors in individual phonemes.

TABLE 2.4 — THE SUPRASEGMENTAL FEATURES AND THE MEANINGS THEY CREATE

Feature	What it is	Minimal example
Word stress	Relative prominence of a syllable inside a word	PHO·to vs pho·TOgraph; REcord (n.) vs re·CORD (v.)
Sentence stress	Which word carries the message focus	"I SAW the cat" (emphatic) vs "I saw the CAT" (answer to "What?")
Rhythm	The pattern of stressed beats across a stretch	"I want to GO and SEE her" — beats on GO and SEE; other syllables squeezed
Intonation	The melody of pitch movement over a phrase	"You are coming." (fall, certain) vs "You are coming?" (rise, checking)
Juncture (pausing)	Where the speaker breaks the stream of speech	"The boy, the girl, saw the dog." vs "The boy the girl saw the dog."
Linking	Sounds joined across word boundaries in connected speech	"pick it up" runs together; "an hour" loses the /h/

Stress

Word stress tells the listener which syllable carries the identity of a word: normally the first in a two-syllable noun (*PHO·to*, *TA·ble*), the second in a two-syllable verb (*be·GIN*). In compounds the primary stress is on the first element and the second is reduced: *BLACKboard*, *book·SELLER*. **Sentence stress** decides which word is the point of it. "*I saw the cat*" is a flat statement until one word is promoted: *the CAT* answers "What did you see?", *I SAW it* answers "Did you see it?" The unstressed words become the grammatical scaffolding — particles, pronouns, auxiliaries — which is why native speakers can drop them and learners, who do not hear the difference, cannot.

Rhythm

English is a **stress-timed** language: its timing is built on stressed syllables, and the unstressed syllables between them are compressed to make room. Ask someone to say "I want to go to the shop today" and you will get four or five strong beats — *I want to GO to the SHOP toDAY* — with the small words rushed. Assamese and Hindi, like most Indian languages, are **syllable-timed**: every syllable gets roughly

equal time. This is one of the most audible differences between an Assamese L1 speaker's English and a native speaker's, and it is a matter of timing, not of accent.

CLASSROOM CONNECTION

Rhythm is best taught with clapping. Say "I want to go to the shop today" while the class claps on GO, SHOP and DAY only, then again with a clap on every syllable; the contrast lands immediately. Song and poetry carry the same work — a familiar English rhyme, or a jhumur or borgeet line given in English, teaches stress and rhythm together without a rule in sight.

Intonation

Intonation is the movement of pitch over a stretch of speech, and it does three jobs: it marks a boundary, it marks the grammatical role of the unit (question versus statement), and it signals the speaker's attitude. Four patterns cover the great majority of classroom speech.

- ▶ **Fall** — high to low. The unit is complete and the speaker is not asking for anything. *"Close the window."* *"The shop opens at nine."*
- ▶ **Rise** — low to high. A yes/no question, an offer, or a request for confirmation. *"Are you ready?"* *"Shall we begin?"*
- ▶ **Fall-rise** — fall then a late rise. Sharing information, surprise, checking a shared understanding. *"But we finished it already!"*
- ▶ **Rise-fall** — rise then a sharp fall. Warning, insistence, or a question that carries "I mean what I say". *"Don't touch that."*

TABLE 2.5 — ONE SENTENCE, FOUR MEANINGS: THE EFFECT OF INTONATION AND STRESS		
Utterance	Suprasegmental marking	Meaning conveyed
<i>What?</i> (falling)	short, level, final tone	Flat, unfriendly: "Is that all you have to say?"
<i>What?</i> (rising)	stretched, rising tone	Surprise, or a genuine request to repeat
<i>I said the ship is fine.</i>	stress + fall on <i>ship</i>	"Not the sheep"
<i>I said the sheep is fine.</i>	stress + fall on <i>sheep</i>	"Not the ship"
<i>I never said she stole my money.</i>	stress on <i>never</i>	Nobody said she did
<i>I never said she stole my money.</i>	stress on <i>never</i> , others reduced	She may well have taken it

2.3 Oral Presentation and Oral Discourses

An **oral discourse** is a piece of spoken language with a purpose, an audience and a shape — a speech at an assembly, a telephone announcement, a news bulletin, a job interview, a shop advertisement, a debate turn. Unlike a casual conversation it is planned, and unlike writing it must work on two channels at once: the words and the delivery. For a student-teacher, constructing oral discourses is doubly useful, because the same text, delivered to a class, teaches children how to organise and deliver speech themselves.

TABLE 2.6 — COMMON ORAL DISCOURSES, THEIR CONVENTIONAL SHAPE, AND CLASSROOM USE

Discourse	Conventional structure	Classroom use
Speech / address	Greeting, purpose, main points in order, illustration, closing appeal, thanks	Assembly topic; "Why we should plant trees"
Announcement	Attention signal, message, repetition, closing ("Thank you for listening")	School notice over the intercom; railway-style announcement
News report	Headline, lead with the most important fact, who-what-when-where, closing detail	School news bulletin; comparing with a real bulletin
Interview	Greeting, opening question, follow-up probes, active listening, thanking, closing	Practising with the head teacher; a book review as an interview with the author
Discussion / debate	Opening, points, counter-points, a concluding statement, keeping to time	"Should homework be banned?" with a chair and a timekeeper
Advertisement	Attention, the product's benefit, credibility, a memorable slogan, a call to action	Write and record an advert for the school's annual sports day
Dialogue / role play	Situation, roles, natural talk, a small conflict or request, resolution	At the shop, at the doctor, a quarrel between two friends

Two things distinguish a good oral presentation from a recited paragraph. The first is **signposting** — the speaker tells the audience where the talk is going: "First I shall explain... next... and finally...", carried on three cards or a chart with three boxes. The second is **support**: a claim is much stronger with an example, a number, a quotation or a short narrative attached to it. In a two-minute talk, one point, one illustration and a closing line is a complete performance.

● 2.4 Opportunities to Use Language in Context

Language is acquired in use, and children will use English in a primary classroom if and only if using English is the easy way to get something done. Two design principles follow. The first is **embeddedness**: the English must be part of something the children want to do — a game, a task, a role, a decision — not an exercise standing on its own. The second is **repetition with variation**: the same language frame is met again and again in slightly different situations, which is how a chunk becomes automatic.

The richest source of context in a school is its own daily life: ordering tea at the canteen, asking the caretaker for a broom, welcoming a guest, announcing a lost-and-found item, telephoning the head teacher about a forgotten book, interviewing a shopkeeper about the price of vegetables. Every one of these uses a small, fixed set of chunks, and every one can be rehearsed until it is secure.

TABLE 2.7 — CREATING CONTEXT IN THE CLASSROOM: FROM THE DAILY ROUTINE TO THE PROJECT

Context	Language children need	How it is organised
Classroom management	"Please stop.", "Look at me.", "Your turn.", "Well done."	Taught once as a phrase, then used consistently by everyone all day
Group work	"What do you think?", "I agree, but...", "Can you explain?"	Sentence frames displayed on the table; every child must speak once before any may stop

Context	Language children need	How it is organised
Story time	Narrative language: "Once upon a time", "Suddenly", "At last"	Teacher models the story, class retells it in pairs, then performs it
Play and games	Turn-taking language: "My turn", "Your go", "That's not fair"	Games that cannot be played without speech
Celebrations and assembly	Formal chunks: "I request to present...", "It gives me great pleasure..."	Rehearsed formally by a small group; a script is fine
Project and survey	Question forms, reporting verbs: "We found that...", "Most children said..."	Real visit, real data, real report to the school

● 2.5 Introduction to Spoken English

Spoken English is the everyday spoken variety of the language, as distinct from the formal, standard or literary English found in textbooks and examinations. A child in Class III uses it for one specific purpose: to be understood by a listener. In the earliest stages almost all of a beginner's English is *formulaic* — fixed phrases rather than constructed sentences — because formulas are stored whole in memory and can be recalled under pressure. Grammar and lexis come later, built on top of them.

This is why "grammar-translation" fails at this level. A child who has only met the pattern "I *am* happy" cannot produce "I want to be happy here"; but a child who has the chunk "What's your name?" and "My name is..." can begin a conversation with a stranger immediately. The practical sequence is therefore: *chunks first, sentences later, grammar last, never separately from meaning.*

TABLE 2.8 — FROM FORMULA TO SENTENCE TO EXPANSION: A THREE-STEP APPROACH TO BEGINNER SPEAKING

Stage	What the child produces	Example
1. Formula	A fixed, memorised expression used as one unit	"How are you?" — answered with "I'm fine, thank you."
2. Substitution	The formula with one slot filled in	"How are <i>you</i> ?" / "How are <i>your parents</i> ?"
3. Expansion	The frame opens up into a question, then an answer with a reason	"How are you?" — "I'm fine, thank you. <i>My tooth hurt yesterday.</i> "

Three further features of beginner spoken English are normal and should not be corrected away too early.

- ▶ **Non-standard forms** (*He has gone* for *He has gone away*) — the child reaching for meaning with the resources he has.
- ▶ **Code-switching** — a word from the home language dropped into an English sentence; a bilingual strategy working, not a failure.
- ▶ **Over-generalised grammar** ("I *am* going" for "I go") — a rule correctly generalised from data that has not yet reached the exceptions.

Each is a stage in development, and the teacher's job is to supply the missing item, not to correct the whole sentence.

● Activities for Unit 2

1. **Theme-based oral interaction and situational conversation.** Choose a theme (a visit to a hospital, buying vegetables, a lost button) and, in pairs, build and perform a conversation in which the language actually does the work of the situation. A phone recording followed by self-transcription is the strongest evidence of improvement.
2. **Listening to and producing oral discourses.** Work through speeches, panel discussions, songs, news reports, interviews, announcements and advertisements. Listen first for gist, then detail, then segmental and suprasegmental features. Produce one of each yourself.
3. **Classroom theatre: role play and drama.** Stage a short scripted episode with props and an audience. This forces every student to speak, to listen, and to adapt in real time.
4. **Giving and eliciting feedback on segmental and suprasegmental features.** Use a simple protocol: a listener names *one thing that worked* and *one thing to try next time*, referring to a specific feature (stress, a particular sound, pausing, intonation) rather than saying "your English is bad".
5. **Storytelling and re-telling.** Retell a story from memory to a partner without the book; the partner notes what was omitted and what was added. Retelling is where the loss of a second language shows most clearly.
6. **Telephonic conversation.** Sit back to back with a partition. Ask for information, leave a message, make an enquiry, apologise for a late reply.
7. **Announcements.** Compose and deliver a 30-second school announcement following the broadcast formula, and check that every message is heard by the class at the back.

UNIT 2 QUICK REVIEW — LISTENING TO AND PRODUCING ORAL DISCOURSES

KEY TERMS

phoneme · allophone · minimal pair · IPA · segmental feature · suprasegmental feature · monophthong · diphthong · stress-timed · syllable-timed · intonation · juncture · linking · oral discourse · formula / chunk · code-switching

REMEMBER

- ▶ English has **44 phonemes**: **24 consonants** (17 obstruents + 3 nasals + 4 approximants) and **20 vowels** (12 monophthongs + 8 diphthongs).
- ▶ Consonants: p b t d k g f v θ ð s z ʃ ʒ h tʃ dʒ m n ŋ l r j w. Monophthongs: i: ɪ e æ a: ɒ ɔ: ʊ u: ʌ ə: ɜ: ə. Diphthongs: eɪ aɪ ɔɪ aʊ əʊ ɪə eə ʊə.
- ▶ /ɜ:/ is **marginal** – loanwords only. **English is stress-timed; Assamese and Hindi are syllable-timed.**
- ▶ Four intonation patterns: **fall, rise, fall-rise, rise-fall**. Three levels of listening: global, selective, detailed.

QUESTIONS

VSA What is the difference between a segmental and a suprasegmental feature? Name the four intonation patterns.

SA Transcribe the following in IPA and identify the segmental contrasts: *ship, sheep, sip, zip, think, this, bench, Ben*.

LA "Listening is the most important language skill and the least taught." Discuss with reference to the three levels of listening comprehension and to the activities prescribed in this unit. (10)

UNIT 3 • 10 MARKS

Critical Reading

● 3.1 Reading Skills and Strategies

A **reading strategy** is a planned way of approaching a text, chosen because it fits the reader's purpose. The purpose decides the strategy, and the strategy decides the speed, the detail, the re-reading and the amount of guessing. The strategies below are not better and worse than each other; each is the right answer to a different question.

Reading aloud and silent reading

Reading aloud is reading with voice, so that the eyes, the ear and the mouth work together on the same text. Its value is not that it is louder: it forces the reader to *pronounce* rather than to guess, it puts punctuation and phrasing under the reader's control, and it makes the text public so that the class hears and discusses it together. It is, however, a *receptive-public* skill and does not by itself build silent comprehension.

The weakness of traditional "round-and-round reading" is that the whole class waits, the fluent reader carries the laggards, and the laggards stop looking at the words and start watching the mouth. Three corrections make it work: read a short paragraph and stop for a real purpose ("Why did he do that?"); give every child a turn in a pair so nobody is a passenger; and follow the read-aloud with a silent, independent task on the same text.

Silent reading is reading for oneself, without voice. It is faster, it frees the reader to re-read and to skip, and it is the mode in which real comprehension happens because nothing has to be performed. But silent reading is invisible, so it must be given a purpose and a product: a question to answer, a summary of three sentences, something to find, a number of minutes.

Intensive and extensive reading

Intensive reading is close, slow, careful reading of a short text to extract every bit of the meaning — vocabulary, structures, argument, tone, the writer's attitude.

Extensive reading is wide, rapid, largely uninterrupted reading of many easy texts, undertaken for fluency, vocabulary growth and the sheer habit of reading. A class that reads four or five short, easy texts a week is doing extensive reading, and its reading rate, comprehension and writing will improve faster for it.

TABLE 3.1 — INTENSIVE AND EXTENSIVE READING COMPARED

Basis	Intensive reading	Extensive reading
Purpose	Accuracy, depth of understanding, analysis of language	Fluency, speed, volume, habit, pleasure
Text	Short, difficult, carefully chosen	Many, easy, self-selected where possible
Speed	Slow; frequent re-reading and dictionary use	Fast; little re-reading, few interruptions
Outcome measured by	Depth of response, close analysis, a written product	Amount read, reading rate, willingness to continue
Typical classroom use	One poem a week, analysed line by line	A reading corner, graded readers, a class library

Skimming and scanning

Skimming is reading fast to get the general idea of a text, without stopping for unfamiliar words. The eyes move in a zig-zag: the first line of each paragraph, the headings and the last line get attention, the rest is caught in a single sweep. The reader leaves with the topic, the overall organisation and the main point. Skimming suits a chapter before a test, and the first ten seconds of looking at any unfamiliar text.

Scanning is searching a text for one specific item — a date, a name, a number, a price, a definition. The eyes move in a straight line or down a column, the rest of the page is ignored, and the search stops the moment the item is found. Scanning suits a timetable, a price list, an index, a dictionary, a noticeboard or a list of marks.

Both are teachable in one lesson: put an unfamiliar paragraph on the board with a heading, a date, a place, a number and a name hidden in it; give the class five minutes to skim for the main idea, then two minutes to scan for the items. Children discover that the two tasks use the eyes in completely different ways.

Scaffolding

A **scaffold** is a temporary support supplied to a learner so that the task becomes possible, and withdrawn as the learner becomes able to do it alone. In reading, the classic scaffold is *supported reading*: a text the children cannot yet read is made readable by the teacher, not by simplifying out all of its content but by supporting it.

- ▶ **Pre-teaching the vocabulary** with pictures, gesture, objects and a first hearing, before the text is opened.
- ▶ **Modelling** — the teacher thinks aloud while reading, showing how a reader works out an unknown word and predicts what comes next.
- ▶ **Shared reading** — the whole class reads a big book or a board-mounted text together, with pointers and repeated chorusing.
- ▶ **Questioning at intervals** to stop and check comprehension before the difficulty arrives.
- ▶ **Story-mapping** — drawing the sequence, or arranging picture cards, before and during the reading.
- ▶ **Re-reading** after the first hearing, when the text is no longer unfamiliar; and **differing roles in pairs** — one child reads, the other tracks the text; then they swap.

The word *temporary* matters. A scaffold that is never withdrawn produces dependence: the child waits to be told and stops trying. A good scaffold is faded deliberately, one support at a time, and the child is told that this is happening and why.

Inference and extrapolation

Inference is the reader's construction of information that is not stated. A text says "The boy put down the bag, took out a book, and began to read"; the reader infers that he is on a journey, that he is waiting for someone. Inference is a *backward* movement: the evidence is on the page and the conclusion is drawn from it, and it must be *available* but *unsaid*.

Extrapolation is a *forward* movement: the reader goes beyond the text to fill in what has not been written. A story stops at "And the old woman opened the door"; the reader supplies the rest. Extrapolation is legitimate in literature, where the point is to see how meaning is completed; it is not legitimate in a factual or scientific text, where the correct response is "the text does not say".

TABLE 3.2 — INFERENCE AND EXTRAPOLATION, AND THE QUESTIONS THAT TEST THEM		
Feature	Inference	Extrapolation
Direction	From evidence in the text to an unstated conclusion	From the text to what the text does not cover
Clue	Present but unstated	Absent; the reader supplies it
Kind of text	Any text	Narrative, literary, argumentative
Typical question	"What can you tell from the fact that...?"	"What do you think will happen next?"
Example	"His shoes were wet." → he has walked through water	"She closed the letter and looked out of the window." → what she read changed her mood
Risk	Over-inference: assuming more than the evidence supports	Under-reading: stopping at what is literally written

Coherence and cohesion

DEFINITION

Coherence: the overall semantic and logical meaningfulness of a text — the fit between the ideas, whether or not any signals are used. **Cohesion:** the network of explicit linguistic devices — reference, substitution, ellipsis, conjunction, lexical repetition, parallelism, deictic reference — that marks how the parts of a text relate.

Coherence is a property of the *text as a whole*; cohesion is the set of *devices* that signal those relations. A text can be perfectly cohesive and still incoherent (well-connected sentences about unrelated topics), and it can be coherent with almost no cohesive devices (a picture book with few words).

TABLE 3.3 — THE MAIN COHESIVE DEVICES, WITH A WORKED EXAMPLE OF EACH

Device	What it does	Worked example
Pronominal reference	A pronoun stands for a noun already mentioned	<i>Ram gave Ravi a book. He was grateful. → He = Ram</i>
Definite and deictic reference	<i>The</i> picks up a known referent; <i>that</i> and <i>it</i> point in space or time	<i>Look at that cloud. It is coming this way.</i>
Lexical repetition / synonym	The same content word returns, or a new expression names the same thing	<i>Rain fell. Water covered the field.</i>
Conjunctions	Signal sequence, contrast, cause and result	<i>First we dug, then we planted. He was tired, but he continued. It rained heavily, so the river rose.</i>
Ellipsis	Words are left out because they are recoverable	<i>Some children came by bus, others (came) on foot.</i>
Parallel structure	Matching forms mark matching relations	<i>He came in, took off his coat, and sat down.</i>
Connectives / adverbials	Adverbial phrases order discourse	<i>However, the plan failed. As a result, they changed it.</i>

● 3.2 Text Types and Their Features

Texts fall into four broad **rhetorical types** according to what their writer is doing: describing something, telling about something, explaining something, or persuading about something. Once a reader can name the type, the type tells the reader what to expect — and expectation is most of reading speed. A reader who knows a text is a *notice* knows not to look for a story in it; a reader who knows it is an *argument* knows to look for a claim and a reason. Alongside these run three rhetorical appeals: *ethos*, the appeal to the speaker's credibility; *pathos*, to the audience's feelings; and *logos*, to logic. An advertisement relies almost entirely on ethos and pathos, a science textbook almost entirely on logos.

TABLE 3.4 — CHARACTERISTIC FEATURES OF THE FOUR RHETORICAL TYPES

Feature	Descriptive	Narrative	Informative / expository	Persuasive / argumentative
Writer's purpose	To give a clear picture of something	To tell what happened	To explain or inform	To convince or change a reader's view
Dominant tense	Present	Past	Present	Present, with modals
Structure	Spatial order (near to far, top to bottom)	Beginning, middle, end; cause-effect sequence	General to specific; definition, classification, cause-effect	Claim, evidence, warrant, counter-argument, conclusion
Typical lexis and person	Adjectives of colour, size, texture; third person	Time markers, dialogue, sequence adverbs; first or third person	Technical terms, numbers, formal connectives; impersonal third, passive frequent	Evaluative adjectives, abstract nouns, modals; first and second person, direct address
Person	Third	First or third	Third, impersonal	First ("I", "we") and second ("you")
Present in	Descriptions, place-writing, picture captions	Stories, fables, news reports, biographies	Textbooks, encyclopaedias, manuals, notices, letters of enquiry	Editorials, advertisements, letters to the editor, speeches

Feature	Descriptive	Narrative	Informative / expository	Persuasive / argumentative
Key test question	What does it look like?	What happened, to whom?	How does it work? Why?	What should we do, and why?

Worked signals of each type

- ▶ **Descriptive** — *"Behind the kitchen the ground sloped down to a brick wall, and the slope was full of ferns... the bricks were the colour of tea."* Present tense throughout; no plot; adjectives of colour and texture; spatial order; linking rather than action verbs.
- ▶ **Narrative** — *"Bhim had never seen the sea. On the morning the family left Dhubri he woke before light... when the water touched his feet he stopped, quite suddenly, and began to cry."* Characters and setting; a plot with a turn; simple past with time markers (*on the morning, when, then*); a change in the protagonist.
- ▶ **Informative / expository** — *"A seed germinates when three conditions are satisfied: it needs water, air and a suitable temperature... each stage depends on the one before it."* A clear topic sentence; general-to-specific ordering; explicit enumeration; impersonal third person; no opinion.
- ▶ **Persuasive / argumentative** — *"Water in our villages is not scarce because there is none. It is scarce because most of what falls is lost before it is used... Let us begin with the schools: one tank, one tap, one habit."* A claim stated in the first sentence and defended; a concession followed by a rebuttal; direct address; all three appeals at once.

The everyday text types

Beyond the four rhetorical types, the syllabus names a set of everyday text types that a primary child meets. They differ not in kind but in *convention* — the expectations a reader brings to each.

- ▶ **News report** — the inverted pyramid: the most important fact first, then supporting detail, then background. Headline, dateline, lead paragraph, body, quotation. Neutral register, past tense, attribution.
- ▶ **Article** — a newspaper or magazine feature with a title, a standfirst, sub-heads and illustrations; may be descriptive, informative or argumentative.
- ▶ **Letter** — a fixed layout: place and date at the top right, address inside, greeting, body, closing, "Yours faithfully" (unnamed) or "Yours sincerely" (named), signature. The most easily assessed of all the text types.
- ▶ **Notice** — the shortest and most functional: a title in capitals, the essential information in short lines, a date and a signature. No explanation, no argument.
- ▶ **Advertisement** — informative and persuasive together, with the persuasive element dominant: slogan, brand name, benefit stated as a promise, a visual carrying much of the message.
- ▶ **Biography and autobiography** — narrative; a biography is third-person and written by another, an autobiography first-person and self-written. Both are shaped by selection.
- ▶ **Jokes and riddles** — short texts that depend on a violation of expectation: the punchline inverts a premise, a riddle gives a definition with more than one solution.
- ▶ **Stories** — narrative, usually with a clear beginning, middle and end, often with a moral. A strong source for retelling and sequencing work.

3.3 Global and Local Comprehension

Comprehension operates at two levels, and a competent reader switches between them without noticing. **Local comprehension** is work at the level of the word, the phrase and the sentence: the literal meaning, the reference of a pronoun, the

connection between a subject and a verb, the connotation of a word, the meaning of an idiom. **Global comprehension** is work at the level of the whole text: the purpose, the structure, the main idea, the tone, the genre, the author's implied attitude, and what the text is doing rather than what it says.

The distinction matters because the two levels demand different questions. A child can read every sentence correctly and still miss the point of a paragraph, and that is a global failure, not a local one. It is also the failure examinations reward, since almost every comprehension question is really a global question wearing a local disguise.

TABLE 3.5 — QUESTION STEMS FOR THE TWO LEVELS OF COMPREHENSION

Level	Unit of work	Question stems
Local	Word, phrase, sentence	"What does the word... mean here?" · "What does the pronoun <i>it</i> stand for?" · "Which two ideas are joined by <i>however</i> ?" · "What is the effect of the word <i>invisible</i> ?"
Global	The whole text, its structure and its purpose	"What is the main point of this paragraph?" · "Why has the writer placed this example here?" · "What would the writer like the reader to think?" · "Which of these headings would the writer accept?"

● 3.4 The Theoretical Postulates of Critical Theory

Reading a text critically means holding it at a distance and asking questions about it that a reader normally does not ask. Four families of question are prescribed by the syllabus, and they are best taught as a set of lenses through which any text — a textbook chapter, a newspaper editorial, an advertisement, a poem — can be examined.

3.4.1 *The concepts used in a text*

Every text rests on a set of concepts — the ideas it takes for granted rather than argues for. *Development, progress, discipline, merit, normal* and *civilisation* do most of the hidden work in educational writing. A critical reader's first task is to **identify the key concepts** and ask: is this concept defined? Is the definition acceptable? Whose definition is it? A chapter on "Good behaviour" that never defines *good* is not being careless; it is relying on a shared assumption.

3.4.2 *The soundness of the argument*

An argument consists of a **claim** (what is being asserted), the **evidence** offered in support, and the **warrant** — the assumption that makes the evidence relevant to the claim.

TABLE 3.6 — TESTING THE SOUNDNESS OF AN ARGUMENT

Question	What it tests	Failure looks like
What exactly is being claimed?	Clarity of the claim	A claim that changes as the paragraph proceeds
What evidence is offered?	Support	Opinion repeated as though it were evidence
Is the evidence relevant?	The link between evidence and claim	Statistics about one district used for a claim about a whole country
Is the evidence accurate?	Truth and verifiability	A number quoted with no source
What is the warrant?	The assumption connecting the two	"Crackers are cheap, therefore the poor are well fed"
Is the counter-argument addressed?	Fairness	A "balanced" article that never states the other side

3.4.3 The value and relevance of the assumptions

Every argument rests on assumptions taken for granted rather than argued for. A critical reader asks about these: are they *worth holding*? Do they *still apply* today? And whose interests do they serve? An argument built on "hard work is rewarded" may be a fine starting point and a poor conclusion, because it assumes that everyone begins with the same resources. An argument built on "children need discipline" is doing something quite different when it is written by a head teacher, a parent and a textbook author, and the critical reader is expected to notice the difference.

Critical reading is not the same as criticism, disagreement or showing off. A student who writes "I disagree because my grandmother says so" has not made an assumption, has tested anything, and has learned nothing. Critical reading means the text is *seriously* taken as an argument before it is judged — "critical" here means careful and exacting, not fault-finding.

3.4.4 The tradition on which the text is based

No text is written from nothing. Every text stands in a **tradition** — of a discipline, a period, a culture, a language, a genre, or a school of thought — and a reader who knows the tradition reads differently. An extract from an Assamese oral tradition, a Victorian moral tale for children, a science textbook, a front-page news report, a WhatsApp forward and a government notice all make different claims about authority: the learned, the child moralist, the expert, the journalist, the crowd, the state. Naming the tradition explains much about the conventions of the text, including the ones a modern reader may find strange.

TABLE 3.7 — THE FOUR CRITICAL LENSES, WITH THE QUESTION BEHIND EACH

Lens	The question behind it	A classroom move
Concepts	Which ideas is the text taking for granted?	List the key terms of a lesson; circle any that are never actually explained
Soundness of argument	Does the evidence support the claim, and is the claim worth supporting?	Separate a paragraph into claim, evidence and warrant using three colours
Assumptions	What must be true for this argument to work, and is it still true?	Ask "what must everyone here already believe for this to make sense?"
Tradition	What kind of text is this, and who is it speaking for?	Compare a news report, a notice and a WhatsApp message on the same event

Critical reading is well within reach of a primary classroom if it is kept concrete. Give a Class VI group a short letter to the editor from your own district and ask three questions: What is the writer claiming? What evidence is offered? What is taken for granted? Then give a different letter on the same topic and ask them to say which one argues better, and why.

● 3.5 The Process of Critical Reading

Critical reading is not a single act of insight at the end of a text; it is a staged process, and the staging is what makes it teachable. A student who skips the first stage has usually already lost the text before it begins.

TABLE 3.8 — THE THREE STAGES OF CRITICAL READING

Stage	What the reader does	Key questions	Product
Before reading	Builds a frame: what do I know, what do I expect, what is my purpose?	What is this text? Who wrote it, for whom, when, and why? What do I already believe about the topic? What am I reading <i>for</i> ?	A prediction and a set of questions to test
While reading	Reads actively, marks up, and monitors: comprehension, structure, language, argument	Where am I losing the thread? What is the writer claiming here, and on what grounds? Which words are doing the work of persuasion? What is left out?	Annotated text, margin notes, a running question list
After reading	Reconstructs, evaluates, responds, and places the text	What is the argument? How sound is it? What assumptions does it rest on? What tradition does it belong to? What have I changed my mind about?	A summary in one's own words, a reasoned response, a review or a debate

Before, settle the *purpose* — skim for gist, read closely for argument, look for a fact, read for enjoyment — because the purpose determines everything that follows; activate prior knowledge; and predict from the title, the headings and the first paragraph. A useful classroom routine is a two-minute "before" routine in which every child writes one sentence: *This text is probably about..., because...*

While, active reading means holding the text, the questions and the marks in view at once. The habits are few and repeatable: **mark up** (underline a claim, box an example, put a "?" beside something not understood, write a one-word reaction at

each paragraph break), **monitor** (pause at each paragraph end and ask "what has just happened, and why has the writer put it here?"), and **read between the lines**.

After, a reading becomes understanding in three moves. **Reconstruct**: put the book down and write what the text said in your own words, then check. **Evaluate**: the four lenses of 3.4 applied to this text. **Respond**: say or write what you think, in a form suited to the text — a summary, a review, a letter, a debate, a diagram, a rewritten ending. A student who can do this third move has read critically, whatever the text was.

EXAMPLE

Before: "This is a chapter on water. I already know water freezes at zero. My question: does it tell me anything I don't know?" While: mark the four claims; notice that no claim has a number attached. After: "The chapter argues that everyone can save water by small habits, but it gives no figure for how much a tap leaks, so I cannot check the claim. Its assumption is that people will change their habits if told." That three-part record is a piece of critical reading, and it takes fifteen minutes.

● 3.6 Miscue Analysis: Errors as Learning

DEFINITION

A **miscue** is an error made while reading; in the sense that matters here it is not a random mistake but the visible result of a strategy the reader is using. If a child reads *house* as "hose", he has picked the wrong item from a visual field in which the two words look almost identical — the error shows he is decoding by shape rather than by sound. **Miscue analysis** is therefore diagnostic: collect the miscue, identify the underlying reading strategy, decide whether it is productive or non-productive, and intervene. It asks not "how many mistakes did the child make?" but "**what is the child doing, and is it working?**"

TABLE 3.9 — COMMON TYPES OF MISCUE, THE STRATEGY BEHIND EACH, AND THE INTERVENTION

Type of miscue	Example	Strategy behind it	Productive?	Intervention
Visual substitution	house → "hose"; come → "some"	Guessing from the shape of the letters	No	Cover the word and read from the sound; say it, then look at it
Contextual over-guessing	"The boy was <i>tired</i> " read as "happy" because the next line said he smiled	Over-reliance on context instead of the print	No	Ask "which word did you actually see? Read it with your finger first"
Letter-name reading	cat → "see-ay-tea"	Alphabet rather than phonemic decoding	No	Re-teach sound-letter correspondence for those letters only
Skipping a line or a clause	Reads only the first word of each line	Preserving reading rate, or avoiding difficulty	No	Silent tracking; ask what was on the lines "in between"
Syllable chopping	"beautiful" → "beau-ti-ful" with an inserted vowel	Attempting to blend from left to right only	Yes	Praise it; this is the reader on the way. Add blending practice
Phoneme substitution	"ship" for "sheep"	The first language's vowel system is operating	Yes	Minimal-pair drill, keeping the word in a real sentence

The goal of miscue analysis is **self-correction**. The reader who notices "that isn't a word, let me look again" is a reader who will manage any text; the reader who is corrected silently until the page is clean has learned only to avoid being caught.

● Activities for Unit 3

1. **Read different texts for discourse analysis.** Collect one example of each of the four rhetorical types and of the everyday types — news report, article, letter, notice, advertisement, story, joke, riddle — and mark the features that make each recognizable: the headline, the greeting, the signpost words, the punchline.
2. **Interpret pictures, tables, graphs and diagrams.** These are texts too. Ask what question a photograph with a caption, a bar chart, a map legend or a flow diagram answers, and what a careless reader would get wrong.
3. **Scaffolding activity: Show and Tell.** Describe an object or photograph in three sentences so that a partner can draw it. The describer chooses features deliberately, the drawer asks for clarification — and both practise supportive listening and precise vocabulary.
4. **Review any book, article or text.** Use a fixed review format developed beforehand in workshop mode: title and author, the type of text, the main idea in one sentence, the parts you liked, the parts you found difficult, one question for the author, and who you would recommend it to.
5. **Use reading as a reference skill.** Practise the four reference tools: the **dictionary** (headword, part of speech, numbered senses); the **encyclopaedia** (read the whole entry, not the first line); the **thesaurus** (find a similar meaning, then choose from context); and the **internet** (who wrote it, what is the evidence, is it a copy of something better).
6. **Collect different types of texts and write model text items.** Build a class collection — a notice, a letter to the head teacher, a lost-and-found announcement, a birthday invitation, a complaint about a broken tap, a school news item, a book review — and keep a model of each.

UNIT 3 QUICK REVIEW — CRITICAL READING

KEY TERMS

reading strategy · intensive / extensive reading · skimming · scanning · scaffolding · inference · extrapolation · coherence · cohesion · rhetorical type · global / local comprehension · claim / evidence / warrant · tradition · miscue analysis · self-correction

REMEMBER

- ▶ Coherence = meaningfulness of the whole; cohesion = the *signals* that tie the parts together.
- ▶ Inference is backward (evidence → conclusion); extrapolation is forward (text → beyond the text).
- ▶ Four rhetorical types: descriptive, narrative, informative/expository, persuasive/argumentative.
- ▶ Global comprehension asks "what is this text doing?"; local comprehension asks "what does this word or sentence mean?"
- ▶ Critical reading has three stages — **before, during, after** — and four lenses: **concepts, soundness of argument, assumptions, tradition**.
- ▶ A miscue is a strategy made visible. Collect, identify, judge, intervene. Syllable chopping and phoneme substitution are productive, not failures.

QUESTIONS

VSA Define coherence and cohesion, giving one difference between them. What is a miscue?

SA Explain the four lenses of critical theory and the question behind each. Distinguish inference from extrapolation.

LA Take a short passage from a primary textbook. Analyse it for (a) its rhetorical type and features, (b) global and local comprehension, (c) its cohesive devices, and (d) the assumptions it rests on. (15)

UNIT 4 • 10 MARKS

Vocabulary in Context

Vocabulary is the whole stock of words a person commands, together with the knowledge of how those words fit together. A vocabulary is not a list but a network: knowing a word means knowing what it means, how it sounds, what part of speech it is, what it collocates with, and what it suggests as well as what it states. A primary teacher's vocabulary is the most valuable resource she can put into a classroom, because the words she uses are the words her pupils will meet.

● 4.1 Understanding Vocabulary and Its Extension

Two facts about vocabulary should be held together. The first is that vocabulary is **the largest single component of language ability**: in any continuous piece of English, roughly three to five words in every hundred carry the bulk of the meaning, and the rest are grammatical filler a reader can guess. The second is that vocabulary does not grow by being taught item by item. It grows by **exposure**, by **rooting** in a context, and by **being used**.

Conscientious is not learned from a list; it is learned when a child meets it in a description of a character, sees its parts (*con-* with, *scire* know, *-ous* full of), and meets it again two days later in a different sentence. Three encounters with a word in real contexts beat thirty encounters in a word list, because the list supplies the word without the *net* around it.

TABLE 4.1 — FOUR WAYS A TEACHER'S VOCABULARY EXTENDS

Mode	What it means	Classroom move
Extension through <i>rooting</i>	Learning roots and affixes so that one root yields many words	Make a family tree from one root: <i>port</i> → import, export, transport, portable, porter
Extension through <i>collocation</i>	Learning which words habitually keep company	Teach "make" not alone but with <i>a decision, an effort, a mistake, friends</i>
Extension through <i>topic</i>	Learning the words of a subject or a situation in one block	A "clothes" or "farming" or "my body" word bank with pictures

Two further terms belong here. **Lexis** is vocabulary considered as a system rather than as a list; **lexical competence** is the ability to use that system appropriately. A teacher who knows a word but cannot use it in a sentence has a fact, not a lexeme. And **receptive** vocabulary (words you recognise when you meet them) is much larger than **productive** vocabulary (words you can use yourself). A child who recognises *obstinate* but has never used it has a receptive word; a child who uses

stubborn correctly has a productive one. The two grow at different rates, and it is normal for a learner to be years behind on the productive side.

● 4.2 Classification of Words: Closed and Open Word Classes

English words divide into two large classes on a single principle: **how readily new members can be added**. The **closed** (or **function**) classes are closed because the number of items in them is small, fixed, and cannot be increased by borrowing or coinage. The **open** (or **lexical** or **content**) classes are open because they are indefinitely large and new members are added every day — by borrowing, by compounding, by derivation, and by invention.

DEFINITION

Closed word class: a set of grammatical items that is finite and relatively fixed. **Open word class:** a set of lexical items with no known limit. **Function word:** a grammatical word expressing a relationship between other words rather than content of its own. **Content word:** a lexical word carrying lexical meaning, able to stand alone as the head of a phrase.

TABLE 4.2 — THE WORD CLASSES OF ENGLISH COMPARED		
Basis	Closed (function) classes	Open (lexical/content) classes
Members	About 100–150 items in total across all the classes	No known limit; hundreds of thousands and growing daily
Can new words be added?	Essentially no — this is what "closed" means	Yes, continuously, by derivation, compounding, borrowing and coinage
Function	Express grammatical relationships: time, number, negation, cause, contrast	Express lexical meaning: the content of the message
Classes	Pronouns, articles, determiners, prepositions, conjunctions, auxiliaries, modals, particles	Nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs
Frequency and stress	Extremely high — 50–60 per cent of all tokens, and normally unstressed	Fewer, but each carries more information and normally carries the stress
Learning burden	Learned by absorption; not sensibly memorised item by item	The main work of vocabulary teaching; extended by roots and context

Because the closed classes number only about 100 to 150 items, they cannot sensibly be taught exhaustively as a list. They are picked up *by absorption*, in the course of using sentences, and they are best taught as *meaning within a structure* — "over there", "have put", "did come" — rather than as isolated words. This is why a child who has never been taught the word "however" can nevertheless use it correctly, and why a child given a long list of conjunctions may still not connect two ideas with one.

TABLE 4.3 — THE CLOSED CLASSES IN DETAIL, WITH THEIR FUNCTIONS		
Class	Members	Function in the sentence

Class	Members	Function in the sentence
Personal pronouns	I, you, he, she, it, we, they	Refer to participants; the <i>it</i> and <i>they</i> forms are also used for objects and things
Articles	a, an, the	<i>a/an</i> = one of many, not yet identified; <i>the</i> = already identified, known to both parties
Determiners	this, that, these, those, my, your, his, her, its, our, their, some, any, each, every, all, no, much, many, few, several	Fix the reference or the quantity of a noun; <i>some/any</i> carry a distinction of expectation
Prepositions	in, on, at, to, for, with, from, by, about, under, over, between, among, during, without, across, through	Relate a noun to place, time, direction, manner or cause
Conjunctions	and, but, or, nor, so, yet, because, although, while, if, unless, since, whereas, whether	Join clauses; <i>coordinating</i> join equal units, <i>subordinating</i> make one dependent
Auxiliaries	be, have, do (in their auxiliary uses)	Carry tense, aspect, voice, mood and question formation
Modals	can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must, ought, need, dare	Express ability, permission, obligation, probability, conjecture
Negative particles	not, n't, never, no, none, nor	Make the whole clause negative

● 4.3 Categories of Vocabulary: Lexical, Phrasal and Clausal

Not all vocabulary consists of single words. A large part of everyday English is made of units of two, three, five or eight words, and these units are stored in the mind whole — as chunks — because their meanings are not predictable from the parts. *Spill the beans* has nothing to do with beans. Understanding such units is not a bonus; it is a large part of understanding ordinary English at all.

DEFINITION

Lexical vocabulary consists of single content words — nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs — and of *compounds* made of two content words written together (*bookshelf, rainfall*). **Phrasal vocabulary** consists of fixed multi-word expressions whose idiomatic meaning is *not* predictable from the parts, and which have no subject–predicate structure of their own (*once in a blue moon, break the ice*). **Clausal vocabulary** consists of multi-word units that do form a clause with a subject and a predicate, and whose meaning is idiomatic (*take care, give up, look after*).

The distinction between **phrasal** and **clausal** vocabulary is often blurred. A phrasal expression such as *a bull in a china shop* is a fixed phrase: you cannot insert other words into it, and you cannot say *the bull was in a china shop* and get the same meaning. A clausal verb such as *look after* takes a subject and an object like any other verb, and its meaning is established by use rather than by composition. Both are learned whole, but a learner who knows *look after* knows a verb; a learner who knows *under the weather* knows a phrase.

TABLE 4.4 — LEXICAL, PHRASAL AND CLAUSAL VOCABULARY COMPARED			
Basis	Lexical	Phrasal	Clausal
Unit	One word, or a compound written together	A fixed multi-word phrase	A verb plus a particle, sometimes with an adverbial
Structure	Noun, verb, adjective, adverb	No internal structure; cannot be varied	Has a subject and a predicate
Predictability of meaning	High for compounds: <i>rainfall</i> = rain that falls	None: the meaning is conventional	None: the meaning is conventional
Position in the sentence	Wherever its part of speech allows	Fixed idiomatic slots	Anywhere a verb can stand, with the idiomatic particle
Examples	kindergarten, classroom, quickly	piece of cake, under the weather, spill the beans	take after, put off, give up, look forward to
How it is taught	By roots, compounds and context	By situation, picture and story, with the meaning made explicit	By example sentences and contrast within the family

TABLE 4.5 — PHRASAL VERBS WITH MEANING AND A MODEL SENTENCE		
Phrasal verb	Meaning	Model sentence
look after	to take care of	She looks after her younger brother every evening.
look into	to investigate	The teacher looked into the problem of absent children.
look up	to search for information in a dictionary	Look up the word <i>conscientious</i> in the dictionary.
look forward to	to await with pleasure	I look forward to meeting your brother.
put off	to postpone	They put off the meeting until next week.
put up with	to tolerate	I cannot put up with this noise any longer.
take after	to resemble a parent	He takes after his father in every way.
turn down	to reduce the volume; also, to refuse	Please turn down the radio a little.
give up	to stop trying	Do not give up if you fail the first time.

Particle shift is the reason one verb-particle combination must be learned as a family rather than item by item. *Turn down the radio* (reduce the volume), but *turn the radio down*; *put the book on the shelf*, but *put on the shelf*. With a noun object the particle may move; with a pronoun it must: "turn **it** down" but "turn down **the radio**". This is why a phrasal verb list without example sentences is not usable in a classroom.

● 4.4 Word Formation: Prefix, Suffix, Compounding and Modifiers

English makes new words in four regular ways, and because the ways are regular a child who knows one root and one ending can produce a word he has never met — which is what makes a dictionary unnecessary for a large part of reading.

TABLE 4.6 — PREFIXES, THEIR MEANINGS, AND THE KIND OF CHANGE THEY MAKE			
Prefix	Meaning	Examples	Effect on meaning

Prefix	Meaning	Examples	Effect on meaning
un-	not, opposite of	unhappy, untie, unlock, unfair	Reverses; the most productive prefix in English
dis-	not, reverse of	disagree, disappear, dislike, disarm	Reverses or negates a verb or adjective
re-	again, back	rewrite, rebuild, return, repay	Marks repetition, often with a result
pre-	before	preview, prepaid, pre-war, predict	Places an action before another
mis-	wrongly	misread, misspell, misunderstand, mislead	Marks an action done wrongly — a very useful set for a reading teacher
anti-	against	antibiotic, antisocial, anti-inflammatory	Opposition to something
trans-	across, beyond	transport, translate, transparent, transmit	Movement across or through

A **suffix** is added at the end of a word and usually determines its **part of speech** — what kind of word it now is. Learning suffixes is therefore a shortcut to grammar as well as to vocabulary. A **prefix** is added to the beginning of a word and usually modifies its meaning; it never changes its part of speech.

TABLE 4.7 — SUFFIXES BY THE PART OF SPEECH THEY CREATE

Part of speech produced	Suffixes	Examples
Noun	-ness, -ment, -tion, -ity, -ship, -hood, -ism, -age, -ance/-ence	kindness, agreement, action, honesty, friendship, childhood, Hinduism, mileage, appearance
Adjective	-ful, -less, -able/-ible, -ive, -ous, -al, -ic, -y, -ish	careful, careless, comfortable, active, dangerous, musical, historic, rainy, childish
Verb	-ise/-ize, -ify, -en, -ate	realise, notify, strengthen, operate
Adverb	-ly, -wards, -wise	quickly, downwards, clockwise

EXAMPLE — WORKED DERIVATIONS

unhappiness = un- (prefix: not) + happy (root) + -ness (noun suffix) → "the state of not being happy". · **unhappily** = un- + happy + -ly → "in an unhappy manner"; three operations packed into one short word. · **re-usable** = re- (again) + use (root) + -able → "able to be used again"; a child who knows this pattern can guess *re-readable* and *re-washable* without ever being taught them. · **child-centred** = child (root) + -centred (adjective) → "organised around the child's needs and interests".

Compounding joins two or more base words to make a new single word whose meaning is usually predictable, though often narrower than the parts suggest. It occurs in three shapes: *closed* (*bookshelf*, *rainfall*, *toothpaste*), *hyphenated* (*mother-in-law*, *twenty-five*) and *open* (*railway engine*, *tea garden*). Some compounds have become so fixed that the parts are no longer analysed at all — *inability*, *eggplant*, *cupboard*. Compounding is the most immediately useful of the four processes for a primary teacher, because the child who can split a word into two parts can attempt an unfamiliar word instead of giving up on it.

A **modifier** is a word that adds information to another word without changing its part of speech. The normal position in English is **before** the noun, and a modifier placed there is a **premodifier**: *a little girl, the blue pen, three ripe mangoes*. A modifier placed **after** the noun is a **postmodifier**: *the girl little with red dress, the mangoes ripe and sweet, a river flowing past the village*. Postmodifiers are rare in ordinary speech and occur mainly in literary and older English and in formal writing.

Their practical use is *emphasis and afterthought*: a premodifier front-loads the information, whereas a postmodifier adds it at the moment of telling. Taking a simple sentence and moving the adjective from the front to the back, then asking what changes in the emphasis, teaches more about word order in twenty minutes than a rule can.

TABLE 4.8 — PREMODIFIERS AND POSTMODIFIERS COMPARED		
Basis	Premodifier	Postmodifier
Position	Before the noun	After the noun
Frequency	Very common — the normal English pattern	Rare — literary, formal, or deliberately emphatic
Effect	Front-loads the information; gives the noun a narrower reference	Adds information as an afterthought; puts a slight emphasis on it
Example	<i>the little old lady with the stick</i>	<i>the old lady little with the stick</i>
Part of speech	Adjective, determiner, numeral, noun used attributively	Adjective, prepositional phrase, relative clause, participle

● 4.5 Word Types: Synonyms, Antonyms, Homophones, Homographs, Homonyms, Phrasal Verbs and Idioms

These relations between words are named for the sake of precision, and a teacher who cannot name them cannot teach the differences to children. Two of them in particular — **homograph** and **homonym** — are constantly confused.

TABLE 4.9 — WORD TYPES COMPARED: THE RELATIONS OF SIMILARITY AND DIFFERENCE			
Relation	What is the same	What differs	Examples
Synonym	Meaning (approximately)	Word form and usually connotation	big / large; happy / glad; begin / start; child / kid
Antonym	Word form and part of speech	Meaning — usually oppositional	hot / cold; tall / short; full / empty; honest / dishonest
Homophone	Pronunciation	Meaning <i>and</i> spelling	bear / bare; pair / pear; two / too; write / right; sale / sail
Homograph	Spelling	Pronunciation, and usually meaning	tear /tɪə/ ~ /téə/; lead /li:d/ ~ /lod/; bow /baʊ/ ~ /bəʊ/; desert; record; minute; sake
Homonym	Both the form (spelling and sound) and the general area of meaning	The specific sense	bark (of a tree) / bark (of a dog); school (institution) / school (of fish); match (stick) / match (contest); bat

Homograph vs homonym. Many textbooks use the two words interchangeably, and in an answer script that is a weakness. A **homograph** is a relation of *form* — the same spelling, usually a different pronunciation, usually a different meaning (*tear, lead, bow, desert, record, minute*). A **homonym** is a relation of *meaning* — the same spelling, the *same pronunciation*, and a shared general sense area, with different specific senses (*bark, school, match, bat*). A test that works: if you can predict the pronunciation from the meaning, it is a homonym; if the meaning is needed in order to know the pronunciation, it is a homograph.

TABLE 4.10 — SYNONYMS AND ANTONYMS, AND THE LIMITS OF BOTH

Type	Example	Note
Exact synonyms	big / large	Rarely exact; always slightly different in register or connotation
Near synonyms	thin / skinny; begin / commence; refuse / decline	The useful kind — choosing between them <i>is</i> the skill of writing
Graded antonyms	good / bad	On a scale, not opposite in every respect
Complementary antonyms	single / married; alive / dead	Strictly opposite; no middle ground
Conversive antonyms	buy / sell; lend / borrow	Reverse the relation, not the property
Relational antonyms	teacher / pupil; employer / employee	Two sides of one relation

Idioms

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning is conventional and not predictable from the meanings of its parts. Idioms are among the most confusing features of English for a second-language learner, since the learner knows every word in the idiom and still cannot guess the meaning.

TABLE 4.11 — COMMON IDIOMS, GROUPED BY THE IMAGE THEY USE

Image	Idioms	Meaning
Food and eating	piece of cake; a pain in the neck; bite the bullet; food for thought	very easy; an annoying person; endure something unpleasant; something worth thinking about
Animals	a bull in a china shop; the lion's share; let the cat out of the bag	needless carelessness; the largest part; reveal a secret
Weather and body	under the weather; a bolt from the blue; raining cats and dogs	unwell; a sudden shock; raining very heavily
Building and objects	break the ice; build a castle in the air; burn the midnight oil	relieve awkwardness; an impractical plan; work late into the night
Time and money	once in a blue moon; cost an arm and a leg; in the nick of time	very rarely; very expensive; at the last possible moment
Action and speech	spill the beans; get cold feet; keep one's fingers crossed	reveal a secret; become nervous; hope for a good outcome

Idioms are best taught through *situation*, not through meaning. Draw a picture of a person who is clearly ill and ask a Class IV child what the class is doing: "He is under the weather." The idiom arrives attached to the situation, which is where a

child will look for it. A second-hand explanation — "an expression meaning ill" — leaves the child with two disconnected items.

● Activities for Unit 4

1. **Analyse the distribution of linguistic elements.** Take a passage of 200 words and count what is in it: how many function words, how many content words, and how many nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs. A class is usually astonished to find that roughly half the tokens are function words — which is precisely why function words cannot be taught exhaustively and content words must be taught deliberately.
2. **Make generalisations on syntactic and morphological properties.** From your analysis, write down what you have found as a rule: "adjectives in this passage come before nouns"; "the -ly adverbs are all manner adverbs"; "the -ness nouns are all abstract".
3. **Check the generalisations against a new passage.** Open a text you have not analysed and test each rule. Some will hold, some will not. A generalisation that survives several texts is a rule; one that fails on the second was a coincidence. This movement — observe, generalise, verify — is what the syllabus means by "generalisation".

UNIT 4 QUICK REVIEW — VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

KEY TERMS

lexis · receptive / productive vocabulary · closed word class · open word class · function / content word · lexical / phrasal / clausal vocabulary · phrasal verb · idiom · prefix · suffix · compounding · pre- / postmodifier · synonym · antonym · homophone · homograph · homonym · collocation

REMEMBER

- ▶ Closed classes: **pronouns, articles, determiners, prepositions, conjunctions, auxiliaries, modals** — about 100–150 items; learned by absorption. Open classes: **nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs** — content words, indefinitely large.
- ▶ Prefixes never change the part of speech; **suffixes usually do**.
- ▶ Phrasal vocabulary = fixed phrase, no clause. Clausal vocabulary = verb + particle, has a subject and predicate.
- ▶ **Homophone** = same sound (bear/bare). **Homograph** = same spelling, different sound (tear, lead, bow, desert, record, minute). **Homonym** = same form, related meaning (bark, school, match, bat).
- ▶ Postmodifiers are rare; they add information as an afterthought and give emphasis.

QUESTIONS

VSA Distinguish between a homophone, a homograph and a homonym, giving two examples of each. What is a premodifier and a postmodifier?

SA How do prefixes and suffixes differ in their effect on a word? Illustrate with five words each.

LA Taking the root *port*, write out as many English words as you can formed with prefixes and suffixes from it, classify each by part of speech, and write a sentence using three of them. (10)

PRACTICUM

Portfolio, Workshop, Working with Words and Reflective Journal

The practicum carries **10 of the 15 internal marks** and is assessed on the evidence produced, not on the intention. All four requirements below begin in Semester I and run through the course.

TABLE 4.12 — THE PRACTICUM REQUIREMENTS AND WHAT EACH PRODUCES

Requirement	What it is	What must be in it	When
Profile and portfolio	A record of the individual work done in the paper, and of the progress made	Every activity, artefact, worksheet, recording, photograph of a display, feedback received and reflection written	Started now; maintained through all four semesters
Workshop	Designing and preparing materials and tools to develop listening, speaking and reading skills	The materials themselves, the design rationale, the lesson or session in which they were tried, and the outcome	At least one full workshop, per the unit plan
Working with words	Vocabulary work drawn from Unit 4	Word families, phrasal-verb charts, idiom picture cards, classification and analysis tables	Ongoing
Collecting and analysing reading materials	Collecting different types of text and analysing them for theme, grammar and inherent information	The collection itself, classified; the analysis of each item; a synthesis across the collection	Ongoing
Reflective journal	A day-to-day record of activities in the institute, with reflection on them	Entries dated, brief, honest; what was done, what was felt, what was learnt, what will change	Maintained throughout the entire course

The **portfolio** is the spine of the assessment, and the discipline it imposes is the point. A trainee who keeps no record cannot show what was done; a trainee who keeps a poor record cannot be assessed fairly. The minimum for a unit is: the activity as planned, the material produced, the evidence of the activity happening, and a paragraph of reflection connecting it to what she learned about her own English. A photograph of a chart on a classroom wall is evidence; a sentence saying she made a chart is not.

REFLECTION — PROMPTS FOR THE JOURNAL

What did I find difficult in this activity, and was the difficulty in the language, in the confidence, or in the task itself? What did I say in the discussion that I would not have been able to say in the first week? Which word did I have to look up today that I did not need to look up last month?

INTERNAL ASSESSMENT

Scheme of 15 Marks

Fifteen of the fifty marks for this paper are internal, divided between the practicum and the unit tests in a ratio of two to one. The balance is deliberate in a subject that asks a candidate to read critically and to produce spoken English, because neither of those can be examined on paper alone.

TABLE 4.13 — INTERNAL ASSESSMENT STRUCTURE

Component	Marks	Evidence required
Practicum	10	Portfolio, workshop materials and report, reflective journal
Unit tests	5	One test per unit, or an equivalent consolidated test, on the unit content
Total	15	Internal component of the 50 marks for the paper

REVISION

Quick Subject Revision

S1.5 PROFICIENCY IN ENGLISH – I — MEMORY SHEET

ESSENTIAL DEFINITIONS

- ▶ **Phoneme** — the smallest unit of sound that can change the meaning of a word. **Phone** — the actual sound produced. **Minimal pair** — two words differing in exactly one phoneme. **Allophone** — a predictable variant of a phoneme.
- ▶ **Segmental feature** — a feature of a single phoneme: manner, place, voicing, aspiration, length. **Suprasegmental feature** — a feature operating over a stretch longer than one phoneme: stress, rhythm, intonation, juncture, linking.
- ▶ **Reading strategy** — a planned way of approaching a text, chosen to fit the reader's purpose. **Scaffold** — a temporary support supplied to make a task possible, and then withdrawn.
- ▶ **Coherence** — the meaningfulness and logical progression of a text as a whole. **Cohesion** — the devices that signal relations between its parts.
- ▶ **Inference** — a conclusion drawn from evidence present but unstated. **Extrapolation** — the reader's supply of what lies beyond the text.
- ▶ **Claim / evidence / warrant** — what is asserted, what supports it, and the assumption that makes the support relevant.
- ▶ **Miscue** — a reading error that reveals the strategy the reader is using. Miscue analysis: collect, identify, judge, intervene.
- ▶ **Closed word class** — a finite, fixed set of grammatical items. **Open word class** — an indefinitely large set of lexical items. **Function word / content word** — expresses a relation between words / carries lexical meaning.
- ▶ **Phrasal vocabulary** — a fixed multi-word expression, no clause structure. **Clausal vocabulary** — a multi-word unit forming a clause with subject and predicate.
- ▶ **Lexeme, lexis, lexical competence** — a word as a dictionary item; vocabulary as a system; the ability to use that system appropriately.

NUMBERS, NAMES AND DATES

- ✓ **44 phonemes** — 24 consonants (17 obstruents + 3 nasals + 4 approximants) and 20 vowels (12 monophthongs + 8 diphthongs). /ɜ/ is marginal.
- ✓ English is **stress-timed**; Assamese and Hindi are **syllable-timed**. Four intonation patterns: fall, rise, fall-rise, rise-fall. Three levels of listening: global, selective, detailed.

- ✓ Committee of Public Instruction's report **1832**; **Macaulay's Minute 1835**; **Wood's Despatch 1854** — "Magna Carta of English education in India".
- ✓ Constitution **1950** (Part XVII; Eighth Schedule, 22 languages); Official Languages Act **1963**; NPE **1968** (three-language formula); NPE **1985**; NCF **2005**; NEP **2020**; NCF-FS **2022** (goals W, L1, L2).
- ✓ Ethos, pathos, logos — credibility, feeling, logic. Closed classes number roughly 100–150 items and are learned by absorption.

FRAMEWORKS TO NAME

- Receptive skills (listening, reading) vs productive skills (speaking, writing); receptive vs productive vocabulary; additive vs subtractive multilingualism.
- The three-language formula; L1 / L2 / foreign language.
- Four rhetorical types of text: descriptive, narrative, informative/expository, persuasive/argumentative.
- Four critical lenses — concepts, soundness of argument, assumptions, tradition; three stages of critical reading — before, during, after.
- Word formation: prefix (never changes part of speech), suffix (usually does), compounding, premodifier and postmodifier.
- Four word relations: synonym, antonym, homophone (same sound), homograph (same spelling, different sound), homonym (same form, related meaning).

PRACTICAL REQUIREMENTS

- Portfolio and profile, workshop, working with words, collection and analysis of reading materials, reflective journal — carried through all four semesters.
- Internal assessment: practicum **10**, unit tests **5** (total internal 15 of 50).

IMPORTANT DIFFERENCES

The Distinctions Most Frequently Examined

TABLE D.1 — CONFUSABLE PAIRS AND THE TEST THAT SEPARATES THEM

Pair	The distinction
Phoneme / phone	The abstract contrastive unit / the actual sound a speaker produces
Segmental / suprasegmental	Carried by a single phoneme / carried by a stretch longer than one phoneme
Word stress / sentence stress	Prominence of a syllable within a word / which word carries the message focus
Stress / intonation	Prominence / the melody of pitch movement
Receptive / productive skill	Incoming, fixed and unpausable (listening, reading) / outgoing, producer-paced (speaking, writing)
Receptive / productive vocabulary	Words you recognise when you meet them / words you can use yourself
Idiom / compound	Meaning not predictable from the parts (<i>piece of cake</i>) / meaning predictable (<i>classroom</i>)
Critical reading / criticism	Careful and exacting about an argument / fault-finding

COURSE INFORMATION

Objectives, Mode of Transaction and Assessment

● About This Subject

The paper is first about the student-teacher's own proficiency, and only then about how that proficiency becomes pedagogy. A teacher unsure of a word, of a sentence stress or of what a paragraph is arguing falls back on translation and rote chorus-reading; a teacher who reads fluently, listens carefully and argues clearly gives her class a model of the language in use. The units move back and forth between the two strands — proficiency in usage (sound system, stress, reading strategies, how words combine) and proficiency in classroom teaching (planning oral discourse, analysing texts of different types, doing vocabulary work that is not a list of disconnected definitions). Because this is a proficiency paper, exposure alone is not enough: the trainee must produce, be heard, be corrected and try again.

● Course Objectives

- ▶ strengthen her own English proficiency, receptively and productively;
- ▶ explain the status of English in India — historical, constitutional and curricular — with accuracy;
- ▶ distinguish L1, L2 and foreign language as they operate in an Assamese classroom, and plan without treating the home language as a defect;
- ▶ develop the four basic language skills and the strategies that support them;
- ▶ describe the segmental and suprasegmental features of English and use IPA to transcribe classroom speech accurately;
- ▶ construct oral discourses — a speech, an announcement, an interview, a discussion — appropriate to a purpose and audience;
- ▶ read different types of texts with comprehension, identifying the features that make each type distinctive;
- ▶ evaluate a text critically: its concepts, the soundness of its argument, the value of its assumptions and the tradition it rests on;
- ▶ use miscue analysis as a window into a reader's strategies rather than as a hunt for mistakes;
- ▶ maintain a portfolio and a reflective journal documenting her work across the four semesters.

● Mode of Transaction

The syllabus prescribes three strands, and all three are needed.

- ▶ **Participating in tasks and activities** that improve proficiency in the receptive and productive skills — the student-teacher does, not just studies.
- ▶ **Text analysis of school textbooks** to build critical literacy: the same book a child reads is put on the table and examined for its grammar of argument, its assumptions and its gaps.
- ▶ **Reflection on one's own learning**, so that the trainee can connect what she struggles with as a reader and speaker to what her pupils will struggle with.

In practice the units are worked through classroom discussion, pair and group work, role play and dramatisation, recorded listening tasks, workshop-based

material construction, close reading, book and article review in a fixed format, and entries in a reflective journal.

● Assessment Structure

TABLE C.1 — HOW THE PAPER IS ASSESSED

Component	Marks	Assessment
Theory (external)	35	Written examination at the end of the semester
Practicum (internal)	10	Portfolio, workshop materials and report, reflective journal
Unit tests (internal)	5	One test per unit, or an equivalent consolidated test
Total	50	

FOR FACULTY AND MENTORS

Notes from the Syllabus

- ▶ **Discuss the content of each unit using different methods, techniques and approaches, and with varied materials.** No single method carries a proficiency paper: the sound system needs choral drill, dictation and analysis; critical reading needs silent study, argument and discussion; vocabulary needs sorting, matching and use.
- ▶ **Carry out the activities listed after each unit, and document and record them properly.** A report on the activity must be prepared and kept for reference and for internal assessment. An activity that is done and not recorded counts as not done.
- ▶ **Carry out the practicum strictly.** It is the assessed part of the paper and cannot be substituted by a written assignment.
- ▶ **Develop the formats for reviewing books, articles and texts, and for workshop activities, beforehand, in workshop mode, with the student-teachers.** Designing a review proforma is itself a piece of critical literacy, and a group that designs it will use it far better than one handed it.
- ▶ **Class assignment:** prepare an individual profile, maintain the profile, and keep a reflective journal.

SUGGESTED READINGS

Policies, SLMs and Reference

1. **NCF 2005** — National Curriculum Framework for School Education, NCERT, New Delhi. For Unit 1.
2. **NCFTE 2016** — National Curriculum Framework for Teacher Education, NCERT, New Delhi. For the proficiency and reflective orientation expected of a teacher.
3. **NCTE / SCERT Guidelines for the D.El.Ed course** — national and state-level guidance on the structure and transaction of this paper.
4. **Resource Materials for the D.El.Ed course** — SCERT, Assam. State context, including the multilingual classroom in Assam.
5. **SLMs for the D.El.Ed course** — self-learning materials published by IGNOU, KKHSOU, NIOS and similar institutions.

6. **OERs and TDUs of TESS-India** — open educational resources at *www.tess-india.edu.in*; particularly useful for listening materials.
7. **Books on spoken and oral English** — including those published by SEBA and other Indian publishers. Unit 2 depends heavily on these.
8. **Books on methods and techniques of teaching English** — the bridge between proficiency and pedagogy in this paper.
9. **www.britishcouncil.org** — freely available teaching and learnEnglish resources, including audio for listening practice.
10. **Policy documents online** — NEP 2020, NCF-FS 2022 and NCF-SE 2023, for the policy content of Unit 1.

Note on sources: the phonemic description of English (44 phonemes, 24 consonants, 20 vowels) follows the standard Received Pronunciation analysis used in Indian teacher-education materials. Descriptions of Assamese phonology in Unit 2 are stated at the level of the major contrasts relevant to teaching English, not as a full phonemic analysis.